

The first step, of course, was to stop the work on the Vostok and Voskhod spacecrafts, which were deemed to be not good enough for a trip to the moon. For two years, Korolev worked tirelessly on the lunar programme, coming up with the Soyuz spacecraft that would eventually become history's most efficient man-made machine for space travel.

However, the Soviet Space Programme suffered another major setback on January 14, 1966, when Korolev died in surgery due to medical complications. With this singular visionary lost, the SSP once again faced internal fighting among the many space designers.

Rocket scientist Vasili Mishin was given the official task of taking over the programme, which newspapers around the world had started to call the 'Moonshot'.

## **Moonshot**

Although Mishin took over the programme in 1966, he did not enjoy the support of his superiors nor his colleagues in the same way that Korolev did. Due to this, the infighting continued and ate into his timeline of delivering on what he was asked to do.

For the lunar mission itself, Mishin decided to continue with Korolev's vision of the Soyuz spacecraft. A lunar excursion flyby was planned for 1967 and the first test of the Soyuz spacecraft itself was scheduled for April of that year.

Korolev's original plan for the flyby was called the Soyuz A-B-V circum-lunar complex, in which the Soyuz spacecraft (carrying two cosmonauts) would rendezvous with two other components – a booster (for propulsion) and a tanker (for fuel) – in Earth's orbit. These components, of course, would be launched via rockets. The resultant vehicle would be capable of making a flyby of the moon and then returning to Earth's orbit again. Here, the cosmonauts would once again disassemble the Soyuz from its two added components and make their way back to earth in the Soyuz spacecraft alone.

## **Soyuz**

The Soyuz spacecraft was initially designed to carry two cosmonauts at a time, but was later expanded to accommodate three passengers. It consists of an Orbital Module, a Descent Module and an Instrumentation/Propulsion Module.

i)Orbital Module – This portion of the Soyuz spacecraft is used by the crew while on orbit. It has a volume of 230 cubic feet, with a docking mecha-